

DO THIS INSTEAD

The first 30 days as a PM decide the next two years

Most new PMs spend month one trying to prove they were worth hiring. They arrive with opinions, spot three broken things in the first week, and start fixing.

That is the mistake. Every idea you have in week one has probably been suggested before, by someone who already knows why it did not happen. You just cannot see that yet.

The first month is for learning what you are actually walking into. Here is the checklist, and the questions worth asking while you still have permission to ask anything.

1 Do not fix anything yet

You will see problems immediately. Write every one of them down and do nothing about them.

The ideas you have in week one are usually ideas someone already raised. There is a reason they did not happen, and until you know that reason you are not proposing a solution, you are repeating a conversation the team already had.

EXAMPLE

Keep a running list titled "revisit in 60 days." Add to it constantly. Open it once, at the end of month two, and see how many still look like good ideas.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you get exactly one first month, and people remember what you did with it. Arriving with answers signals you were not listening.

2 Learn the organization before the product

- ☐ Read what the company actually does. Find a sales deck, not the internal wiki. Sales decks are written to explain the business to strangers, which is what you are.
- ☐ Get the org chart and work out who really decides things, which is often not what the chart says.
- ☐ Find out where the company wants to be versus where it is now.
- ☐ Check the documentation guidelines, tools, and templates so your first doc does not look foreign.
- ☐ Chase down access to every internal tool early. It always takes longer than you expect.

EXAMPLE

Ask whoever onboards you for the deck they use with new customers. Read it twice before you read a single PRD.

WHY THIS MATTERS: product decisions that look irrational usually make sense once you understand the business model. Learn the money first and half the confusion disappears.

3 Meet the engineering lead before the stakeholders

- ☐ Set a one to one with your manager, your engineering lead, and every business stakeholder attached to your product.
- ☐ Introduce yourself to the dev team as a group before booking individual time, and say what you will be responsible for.
- ☐ Understand the architecture at a high level, the sprint cycle, and how the teams actually work together.
- ☐ Ask the engineering lead about current technical limitations and the constraints nobody writes down.

EXAMPLE

In every intro, ask two questions: what are you working on, and what slows you down. Then stop talking and take notes.

WHY THIS MATTERS: your engineers decide whether you are worth listening to in the first few weeks, and they decide it from whether you are curious or performative.

4 Learn the product like a user, then like an owner

- ☐ Get access to the real product, including staging, and use it yourself. Not a demo, the actual thing.
- ☐ Find the vision and the existing strategy, if either exists in writing.
- ☐ Work out what stage the product is in, who the key stakeholders are, and what problem it actually solves.
- ☐ Identify the users who matter most. The small group generating most of the revenue is rarely the loudest group.

- ☐ Read existing customer feedback before anyone summarizes it for you.
- ☐ Find the metrics, the dashboard, who sets the targets, and whether they connect to company goals at all.
- ☐ Find the roadmap, who owns it, how often it changes, and who is allowed to change it.

EXAMPLE

Spend one full afternoon using the product as a customer would, with no documentation open. Write down every moment you got confused.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you will be asked to prioritize long before you understand the system. Everything you learn in month one is what makes those calls survivable.

5 Ask what you should not be working on

Everyone asks their manager what the priorities are. Almost nobody asks the more useful question.

Ask what is not yours. Ask what previous people in this seat got wrong. Ask what would make them think, three months from now, that hiring you was the right call.

EXAMPLE

In your first one to one, ask directly: what should I not be spending time on. The answer tells you more about the role than the job description did.

WHY THIS MATTERS: most new PMs fail on scope, not on skill. They spend three months being useful at things nobody needed them to do.

Thirty days is not long enough to change anything. It is long enough to understand why things are the way they are, which is the only thing that makes the next eleven months work.

Observe first. Write everything down. Then earn the right to change something.